BUILDING AFRICA'S FOOD TRADE CORRIDORS

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Efficient cross-border food trade can make or break agricultural margins. For farmers and processors alike, time is money, and in the world of perishables, every extra form, inspection, or delay can cut directly into shelf life and profit. Across Africa, post-harvest and logistics losses for perishable goods often reach between 30% and 50%, largely due to weak cold-chain systems and slow border procedures.

Tariffs and inconsistent customs rules further raise costs, limit smallholder access, and slow down regional food trade. The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) offers a framework to ease these frictions, but success depends on upgrading corridor infrastructure, digitising customs systems, and aligning policies. Products most at risk, like citrus, berries, avocados, chilled beef, poultry, milk, and fresh vegetables, illustrate how delays at borders can wipe out months of investment and labour in hours.

The current challenge

Agribusinesses across the continent face four interconnected barriers:

- High tariffs and para-tariffs: Duties on key goods often total 20-40%, hurting competitiveness and limiting intra-African trade.
- Fragmented customs processes: Duplicated paperwork, manual data entry, and inconsistent rules create multi-day queues for trucks and refrigerated containers.
- Divergent Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS) Standards: Repeated sampling and certification add unnecessary cost and delay.
- Unequal burden on SMEs: Smaller agribusinesses lack the financial cushion to absorb spoilage or cover added transport and storage expenses.

The result? Lower farm-gate prices and higher consumer costs. Staple crops such as maize, wheat, soya beans, and sunflower oil are affected alongside high-value exports like table grapes, blueberries, potatoes, and tomatoes.



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Food trade corridors as a strategic solution

A food trade corridor is more than a road; it's a combination of infrastructure, smart regulation, and coordinated operations. On established and emerging routes such as the North-South Corridor and the LAPSSET (Lamu Port–South Sudan–Ethiopia Transport) Corridor, four priorities can transform outcomes:

- Harmonised documentation: Single-window submissions, pre-arrival processing, and digital phytosanitary certificates to streamline clearance.
- Green lanes for perishables: Risk-based inspections and strict time limits to protect freshness.
- Shared cold-chain infrastructure: Plug-in points, reefer staging areas, and cold rooms at borders and ports to maintain temperature control.
- Digital customs platforms: Interlinked systems connecting customs, SPS agencies, ports, and logistics operators for real-time coordination.

Together, these measures can cut clearance times from days to hours, reduce temperature breaks, lower rejection rates, and boost reliability for retailers and food service buyers across the region.

Agribusiness partnerships to drive progress

While policy reform remains essential, private-sector collaboration can significantly accelerate the creation of efficient food trade corridors across Africa. Strong partnerships between government, industry alliances, and agribusiness players can turn policy ideas into measurable progress on the ground.

One key opportunity lies in collective lobbying under the AfCFTA. By working together, industry alliances, from citrus and berries to meat and grains, can present evidence-based proposals for tariff reductions, seasonal duty suspensions, or quota windows that align with harvest cycles. This collective voice strengthens advocacy efforts and ensures that trade policies are tailored to real production timelines and market needs.

Public-private pilot projects offer another fast track to results. Governments and agribusinesses can co-design simplified, standardised customs forms, implement pre-clearance systems for selected perishables, and test mutual recognition of accredited laboratories to avoid duplicate testing. These pilots can serve as practical demonstrations of how harmonised processes reduce costs and clearance times.

In parallel, shared investment in infrastructure — such as co-financing cold chain nodes, cross-docking facilities, and digital traceability systems — helps maintain product quality, ensures compliance, and builds buyer confidence. When private investors and governments share responsibility for logistics upgrades, both sides benefit from improved trade efficiency and reduced spoilage.

Lastly, knowledge exchange on SPS standards is critical. Joint training and audit programmes can help align safety and phytosanitary protocols across borders, reducing onboarding times for SMEs entering export markets and ensuring consistent quality across the supply chain.

Such collaboration benefits both public and private actors. Governments advance their food security and trade objectives, while businesses gain access to larger, more predictable markets, faster inventory turnover, and fewer losses across key value chains, including beef, poultry, citrus, apples, grapes, and vegetables. Together, these partnerships can build the trust, systems, and infrastructure needed to unlock Africa's regional agribusiness potential.

Moving toward a future of food security

Reducing tariffs and streamlining customs processes offers one of the most direct paths to stabilising prices and strengthening Africa's food systems. Food trade corridors provide a practical blueprint, aligning paperwork, digitising controls, protecting the cold chain, and tracking performance across borders.

The next step is clear: select two high-impact trade lanes, launch public-private pilots, publish measurable savings in time, cost, and rejection rates, and then scale. With focused execution, Africa can unlock integrated regional value chains from cereals and oilseeds to meat and horticulture, moving decisively toward a future of food security, competitiveness, and shared prosperity.